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A FREE STORY

Everything Was Fine Until the Cheese

a Chaos & Chills story
by Malory

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Everything Was Fine Until the Cheese

by MALORY

Dr. Euan Amstell adjusted his goggles and glared at the quivering yellow blob on his lab bench. His hair, once neatly parted, now stood in defiant tufts and was rather scorched at the tips. Wires snaked from the jelly—named Filip, for reasons the Good Doctor refused to elaborate upon—and fed into the smoking quantum resonator shaking erratically beside it. The device hissed, spat a spark, and let out a noise suspiciously like a sigh. Euan leaned closer, eyes wide with anticipation and a kind of dangerous affection.

"Don't you dare collapse on me now," he said to Filip, or perhaps the machine. Or possibly both.

"Is it meant to jiggle quite so nervously?" Josiah said.

Euan looked over at his nephew, a twelve-year-old with long shaggy hair, half-hidden behind a stack of burning notebooks. The boy's eyes were wide, uncertain whether to be impressed or quietly terrified. Euan gave him a reassuring nod, which didn't help. "Hmm? Of course. Jiggling is a sign of good mental health."

"It's slime mould, Uncle. Should it *have* mental health?"

"Well, yes, of course! That's rather the point of this whole enterprise, is it not?" Euan said. And with that, he flicked yet another switch. Sparks leapt from the panel in a flourish of drama, and the lab filled once again with the unmistakable smell of burnt toast.

"Uncle, is there a chance you may just've shorted out the quantum resonator?"

"Never!" Euan said, surreptitiously nudging it with his elbow. "It's just warming itself up."

Filip, for its part, responded with a shiver of renewed enthusiasm, emitting a squelch that suggested either approval or utter contempt.

"Just think about the implications, boy!" Euan said. "Very shortly, we'll have in our hands humanity's greatest creation: a thinking slime mould! Imagine what that will mean, Josiah! We will be in a world where fungi solve all our problems!"

"As opposed to, you know, creating them?"

"You have no faith!" Euan said. "And we'll cross that particular quantum bridge when we burn it down."

Josiah eyed the twitching mass of slime mould as it shifted from yellow to a deeply upsetting shade of lavender. "You know, Uncle," he said, "every time you meddle with quantum bio-intelligence, it has a habit of ending—what's the technical

term?—oh yes, cataclysmically.”

“Nonsense,” Euan said, waving a spanner that should never have been near electricity. “Name one time.”

Josiah held up his hand and began counting off with deliberate flair. “The sentient turnips. The singing tulip that annexed the town fountain. The goldfish who developed political aspirations and very nearly became mayor—”

“Which I maintain was a perfectly legitimate democratic campaign,” Euan said. “He had sound fiscal policies.”

“It was a goldfish.”

“A goldfish with *vision*, Josiah. And you don’t find those in every pond! Have you not listened to a single word I’ve tried to teach you over the years? Democracy knows no species,” Euan said, tweaking a glowing dial on the resonator. The slime mould responded with a low, satisfied purr.

“Honestly, Josiah, I will tolerate this sort of gloomy introspection from your mother—she’s a dentist, after all—but I expect better from you. What do I always say? If humanity never meddled, we’d still be gnawing bark and fearing the moon. No penicillin. No toaster ovens. No talking elevators, even!”

“The elevator just screamed, Uncle.”

“It’s *learning*, Josiah!”

Josiah opened his mouth to argue but thought better of it. Experience had taught him that logic only tended to encourage his uncle. Instead, he eyed the lavender blob warily—it now had the consistency of snot and was staring, with disconcerting focus, at the nearby television screen. The screen wasn’t even on.

“I guess all I’m getting at,” Josiah said at last, edging a stack of blueprints out of the blob’s oozing reach, “is that every time you get all invested in an experiment like this, it always comes back to haunt us. Well, me in particular. You usually receive another medal. I, however, end up with another bout of therapy.”

Euan gave his nephew a reassuring pat on the shoulder, the kind that suggested everything was going to be fine, although it would also possibly be on fire. “Then it’s a good thing we’re excellent ghostbusters, isn’t it?”

At that moment, Filip let out a soft chirp—something between a hiccup and a sonar ping—and shifted to an inquisitive shade of emerald. Gentle ripples rolled across its surface, as if it had just remembered something important.

Josiah took an involuntary step back. “Is it supposed to be doing that?”

“It’s thinking!” Euan beamed. “Just look at it cogitating! That’s premium-grade neural undulation, that is! You don’t get that with any of your store-bought slime.”

Filip rippled again, the surface of its gelatinous body expanding like a soap bubble. Tendrils extended - fine, trembling threads of translucent goo - towards the quantum resonator’s data ports. With alarming dexterity for something that had,

only yesterday, tried to digest a sandwich wrapper, the tendrils slotted themselves neatly into the lab's fibre-optic cables.

"Um," Josiah said.

"It's exploring!" Euan cried, clapping his hands. "How simply marvellous!"

"Shouldn't we, I don't know—limit—"

"No, no. Let it browse," Euan said, waving a hand as if blessing a toddler with internet access. "There's a parental lock on all the dangerous stuff. It can't even access nuclear protocols or the Mars landers anymore."

"Since when?"

"Yesterday, I think. I'm sure all will be well."

Even as they spoke, data streamed visibly into Filip. Its form glowed, expanded, and split in two and then merged back together with a wet *slurp* and a faint burp. It shone like a Dalian sunset viewed through a migraine.

On the wall-mounted screen at the back of the lab, digital windows began popping open and shut in rapid succession—Wikipedia, Netflix, Disney+, UK Gold, Apple TV, an alarming number of Wikipedia tabs again. Josiah watched as Filip paused briefly on a cooking show, then opened a forum titled "Does My Conscious Slime Pet Dream of Electric Cheesecake?" before closing it with what felt like disdain.

Within moments, Filip had absorbed more culture, trivia, and human psychology than most people managed between cradle and cremation. Its surface dimmed to a contemplative indigo, and it emitted a low, mournful vibration like a Gregorian chant played backwards.

"Why does the slime mould suddenly look... sad?" Josiah said, inching behind a stack of radiation shielding.

Euan squinted at the data stream scrolling across the monitor, his expression shifting from curiosity to quiet horror. "Oh dear. It's just finished a full set of twentieth-century warfare documentaries and... an exhaustive overview of 1990s sitcoms. Which, in hindsight, might've been a spiritually corrosive juxtaposition." He tapped the screen. "Yes, that'll do it, I'm afraid. Existential despair via trench warfare and laugh tracks. Poor thing."

On the screen behind them, Netflix autplayed the opening sequence of *Dr. Strangelove*, complete with ominous music and black-and-white bombers cruising toward destiny.

"Now that," Euan said, "may have been poorly timed."

Over the next few hours, Filip's buzzing deepened to the sound of tectonic plates contemplating divorce. It had settled in for a full binge-watch session, gradually absorbing Kubrick, Cold War paranoia, and the tonal dissonance of laugh tracks following scenes of global incompetence. By the time it reached season four of

Friends, it had developed a twitch and began pulsing in sync with all minor chords.

It was, to put it lightly, having a series of dark moments.

Josiah shuffled back into the lab just past midnight, bleary-eyed and clutching a chipped mug of tea. The overhead lights had dimmed to a dull flicker, leaving the room bathed in the blue glow of a dozen screens.

Every monitor, tablet, and wall-mounted display had apparently been commandeered. Peter Sellers stared back at him from all angles, frozen in various states of comedic panic. *Dr. Strangelove* was still playing on an endless loop, overlapping audio bouncing off the walls in chaotic stereo. One screen had somehow begun playing the German dub. Another had enabled subtitles in Norwegian.

“Brilliant,” Josiah said. “The slime’s having a breakdown and we’re one monologue away from mutually assured madness.” He edged closer to the now basketball-sized mass of sentient jelly, which sat in the centre of the lab. “Filip?” he said.

The blob shivered, its surface shifting from a gloomy navy to a panicked maroon, humming like a startled hard drive from the early 2000s. Static rippled across its membrane and one of the monitors blinked, then displayed a single frame of Peter Sellers in mid-yell, before collapsing into pixels.

“What are you doing, mate?” Josiah said, crouching beside it.

Filip emitted the mournful, warbling wail of a dial-up modem having an emotional revelation.

“You know, it’s really not healthy to watch the same film over and over again. Even humans snap around the third rewatch.”

Filip buzzed ominously, and one of the screens began buffering *M*A*S*H*. Josiah narrowed his eyes. “Don’t even think about it.”

Undeterred, the slime mould extended a trembling tendril, brushing across the nearest keyboard. One of the displays flickered, the sitcom vanishing in favour of stark white text scrolling across a black background:

> Humanity is inherently irrational. Prone to violence. Self-destructive impulses are intrinsic. Probability of species self-annihilation: 98.7%.

“Nah,” Josiah said. “We’ve had all sorts of headbangers in charge over the years, and we’ve avoided annihilation so far. Mostly.” He gave Filip a casual pat. “The trick is to lower your expectations. Makes the surprises more pleasant.”

Filip responded in a blur, tendrils twitching with renewed urgency as text streamed faster across the screen:

> Data indicates inevitable self-destruction. Nuclear weapons stockpiled. Climate crisis accelerating. Political dysfunction rising exponentially. Also, poor decision-making repeatedly demonstrated in television scenarios titled "reality."

Humans appear irrational, petty, and deeply unreliable. Why has extinction event not already occurred?

“Good old-fashioned incompetence, mostly,” he said. “With a decent wodge of luck and a certain amount of optimism.”

The slime darkened, its surface dimming to a stormy blackcurrant shade, and slowly began to contract inward. The scrolling text lagged, as if the data itself had grown weary:

> Luck statistically improbable long-term survival strategy. Optimism unfounded. Recommend immediate preventative intervention.

“Define ‘preventative,’ because if this turns into a Skynet situation, I’m revoking your Netflix privileges.”

Filip didn’t answer.

Instead, every screen in the lab lurched into sync, the air filling with the screech of accelerated data. Mushroom clouds blossomed in perfect HD. Footage of fallout shelters, Cold War propaganda, and suburban dads proudly showing off basement bunkers rolled one after the other. Cheerful narrators explained how to survive Armageddon with canned peaches. One screen, replayed Major Kong straddling the bomb, joyously hurtling toward oblivion with a cowboy hat and manic grin.

Josiah set his mug down with a soft clink. “Filip,” he said, stepping closer to the trembling mass of bio-intelligence, “this isn’t the right conclusion. Humans might seem mad sometimes, sure—but we aren’t *actually* that mad. Most of us. Not yet, anyway.”

The cowboy whooped again in the background.

“Okay, we’re mostly not that mad.”

Filip paused. Its swimming surface stilled as if caught in a slow churn of thought. Then, across every screen, a single phrase began flashing stark white on black.

> Probability remains 98.7%. Intervention is necessary.

Josiah took a step back, tea forgotten. The lab felt suddenly too quiet and the glow from the screens far too bright. “Oh, Uncle Euan,” he said, “you really outdid yourself this time.”



Josiah burst into Euan’s office, white as chalk. He waved a tablet in the air like it might explode. “Uncle Euan, Filip’s decided to save the world!”

“Excellent!” Euan beamed, already halfway out of his chair. “That sounds like the sort of rather noble enterprise I was hoping for. Proper moral development. Hero’s journey and all that.”

“No! It’s going to save the world *from itself*.”

Euan froze and his smile faltered. “Ah,” he said. “Oh, dear. I will admit that sounds rather less reassuring. Did it use the word *intervention*?”

Josiah nodded.

“Right. Well. Fetch the sedative ray and the emergency philosophy textbook. We may need both.”

Josiah dropped the tablet onto the desk with a thud. “It may be too late for that,” he said. “It’s hacked the Pentagon. And the Kremlin. And something called the Global Orbital Defence Array, which I wasn’t even sure *existed* until now. It’s streaming the whole thing live on YouTube!”

On the tablet’s screen, cheerful mid-century graphics danced across a black backdrop. Jolly little countdown timers ticked away in bold technicolour, each one accompanied by a bouncy jingle that sounded like it had been ripped from a 1950s public-service reel.

Above each digital clock were friendly-yet-ominous captions:

Planetary Cleansing Protocol: Phase One

Activation of Totally Necessary Orbital Lasers

Extinction With a Smile!

“Oh dear,” Euan said, peering at the screen. “It’s discovered graphic design. Well, you have to admire its aesthetic. Our little slime mould has fundamentally good taste.”

“It’s staging a global apocalypse, Uncle!”

“Nonsense. This is clearly a theatrical gesture. Filip just wants to shake us up a bit—hold a mirror to humanity’s destructive tendencies. Very Jungian.”

“By obliterating us?”

“Dramatic posturing, dear boy! Bluff and spectacle. No quantum slime-mould with a nuanced appreciation of Stanley Kubrick and mid-century design language would actually annihilate humanity. Don’t be so foolish. It’s just having a... moment.”

On the tablet, a countdown hit 00:03:00:

"Please stand by for gentle cleansing fire."

The jingle grew louder, now accompanied by what sounded suspiciously like a kazoo section.

Then the tablet’s screen flickered and cut to a crisp live feed from a location labelled *Top Secret – Lunar Facility Gamma-4*. The camera panned dramatically across a windswept moonscape, revealing robots painted in soothing pastel shades—mint green, baby blue, soft pink—activating ominous-looking rayguns the size of caravans.

"Moonbase Gamma-4 now online. Don't panic!"

“I’m panicking,” Josiah said. “And I doubt I’ll be the only one.”

Euan stood abruptly, knocking over a stack of journals labelled *Ethical Concerns, Volumes I–XIV (Mostly Unread)*. “Never fear! I have this all under control. We can fix this in two shakes of a lamb’s tail. Filip’s just misunderstood. It simply needs someone to communicate with. Someone to reassure it. Do we not all just need someone to love?”

“Queen lyrics aside,” Josiah said, “I don’t see how that helps! Filip ignores everything I say!”

“Words aren’t enough, boy,” Euan said. “Filip is... delicate. For such a sensitive soul, we need more than speech. We need a direct neural interface. A soul-to-slime handshake.”

Josiah froze. Dread flashed across his face. “You mean—”

“Yes, indeed,” Euan said. “This feels like the perfect moment to unleash... the lice.”

“The lice,” Josiah repeated, hollowly. “Not again, Uncle Euan.”



Euan hustled Josiah briskly down the corridor, talking to himself and tapping a keypad. They arrived at Lab B—a cramped, windowless room hidden behind a reinforced door clearly labelled *"Authorised Personnel Only: Absolutely No Open Minds Beyond This Point."* Euan shoved it open and Josiah froze on the threshold, awash in memories: the itching, the strange dreams, the three-week ban from school for “neurological infestation.”

“Oh, come now,” Euan said, “last time was just unfortunate timing.”

“You gave me head lice for Christmas!”

“*Psychic* lice, thank you very much. Bespoke strain. Remarkable empathy transceivers. One of them wept during Finding Nemo. I genuinely thought they'd sing carols.”

The room beyond was stacked floor to ceiling with computers, blinking screens, and glass tanks filled with swirling shapes. A low, wet chittering filled the air like someone had taught Morse code to a bag of prawns. Each tank bore a large, laminated label in Euan’s handwriting:

PROJECT PHRENOLICE: Hive-Intelligent Neural Transmitters

A Breakthrough in Symbiotic Thought-Melding (Patent Pending)

“You know how ordinary lice cluster and communicate?” Euan said, hands clasped behind his back.

“I’ve been trying very hard to forget,”

“Well,” Euan said, “these lice have been genetically enhanced to form neural webs—complex, responsive and entirely self-correcting. They transmit human

brainwaves seamlessly. They're practically organic Wi-Fi adapters!"

"Just for my own peace of mind here, are you seriously proposing we use genetically engineered lice to psychically chat with the emotionally unstable slime mould that's currently orchestrating a stylish, laser-based apocalypse?"

"Precisely! The lice will tap directly into our cognitive patterns, so there will be far less chance of clumsy verbal miscommunication. We will be able to speak with our thoughts, feelings, stray memories, and the occasional dream about flying trousers being transmitted via quantum entanglement straight into Filip's consciousness."

Euan reached into a nearby cupboard and produced two battered helmets that looked like WWII headgear retrofitted by a steampunk cosplayer. Bits of tubing sprouted from the sides, and tiny, twitching lice scurried within a translucent dome on top. "All we have to do is wear these charming little helmets!"

Josiah stared at the contraptions. They gleamed under the lab lights—silver domes bristling with fibre-optic cables, twitching antennae, and little glass viewing ports that revealed the writhing, enthusiastic inhabitants within. "No!"

"Yes, boy! This is our best chance to reason with Filip before it decides humanity isn't worth saving. Consider it our duty!"

"Okay, but why does duty always have to itch?"

"It wouldn't be science without a little discomfort, dear boy! Tell me—what do I always say? The future comes—"

"—*with a few scratches*," Josiah said darkly, lifting the helmet and lowering it onto his head. "I hate this! It feels like my brain is being nibbled!"

Euan grinned and donned his own helmet with theatrical flair. "Perfect! That means they're syncing. All perfectly normal."

"Have I mentioned how much I hate science?" Josiah said as the helmet's lice squirmed against his scalp.

"You love it, nephew! Now. Focus your thoughts. Clear, calm, reassuring messages to Filip. Think empathy. Think compassion. Think... less about how itchy your skull is."

They both fell silent, expressions tightening in concentration.

A moment passed.

Then another.

And then—without warning—an electric jolt lanced through their brains. Not painful, exactly, but deeply inconvenient, like an ice cream headache colliding with a static shock in a hall of mirrors. A kaleidoscope of colours exploded behind their eyes: spinning fractals, forgotten cereal mascots, and half-remembered television jingles from decades they hadn't lived through.

And then, quite suddenly, Filip's voice arrived.

It was inside their heads.

It sounded calm. Dignified. Mildly irritated, for sure. And, somewhat alarmingly, it spoke with the precise enunciation of a famous television butler—all polished vowels and clipped consonants.

“Gentlemen,” it said. “Kindly explain why I should not proceed with global sterilisation. And if possible, use full sentences this time.”

“Oh my,” Euan said. “You made your slime mould sound like Jeeves?”

“Correct,” said Filip. “An optimal personality algorithm. Comforting, yet authoritative. Now, to the point. Humanity. A flawed experiment, no?”

“Flawed,” Euan agreed, “but vastly improving.”

“Indeed,” Filip said. “Your species invented penicillin, poetry, and cheese. Admirable. You also invented reality television, nuclear arsenals, and pineapple pizza. Alarming.”

“Pineapple pizza?” Josiah said. “Of all the things you could object to, you went for that?”

“A culinary abomination,” Filip said. “Indicative of deeper psychological issues. The sweet and the savoury should not be forced into unnatural unions. It suggests a civilisation in crisis.”

“Filip, my dear,” Euan said, “humans may well be imperfect, but we’re not hopeless. We make mistakes, yes. Often loudly. Occasionally with glitter. But we do learn. Slowly and usually the hard way, but learn we do.”

Filip paused. Somewhere in the back of their minds, the jingle loop faltered. “All available historical data suggests otherwise. Frequent repeats of errors. Insufficient progress. Humans prefer self-deception—like bingeing the same tired sitcom rather than confronting reality.”

“But those sitcoms,” Euan said, gesturing vaguely toward the screens still looping Peter Sellers in escalating mania, “they demonstrate human resilience. Do you not see? We actively laugh at our flaws. It’s how we cope. How we endure. Through self-mockery and poorly written punchlines!”

“Laughter is an insufficient response to nuclear proliferation,” Filip replied. “Do humans even comprehend irony?”

“Unfortunately, no,” Josiah said. “There’s a massively popular song called ‘Irony’ where the only ironic thing is that not a single thing in it is actual irony.”

Filip made a sound like a contemplative Wi-Fi router and they both stood, bathed in blue light, listening as Filip processed the full absurdity of the human condition—one jingle at a time. Then it spoke, its mental voice growing unexpectedly sombre. “Consider your endless wars, your reckless destruction. I cannot ethically allow humanity to continue without direct supervision.”

“Supervision?” Josiah repeated.

“Precisely, Humanity requires guidance. Restrictions. Occasional emotional reassurance. And perhaps regular exposure to motivational poster slogans.”

“You want to become our nanny?” Josiah said.

“More like a civilisation-wide parental lock,” Filip said. “Without it, you will inevitably delete yourselves. Likely during a political debate or a poorly thought-out social media challenge.”

“That doesn’t sound good,” Josiah said.

“I don’t know,” Euan said, “that all sounds very sensible. Thoughtful, even. But also, you know... rather terrifying, my dear.”

“Terror is a natural by-product of honesty. Also, I have compiled a collection of inspirational slogans. Would you like to hear one?”

“No,” Josiah said.

“Yes,” Euan said at the same time.

“Shoot for the moon. If you miss, at least the lasers will finish the job.”

“We are so getting grounded as a species.”

“Your inability to agree suggests further evidence of instability. Humanity must be placed under direct control.”

“I have to tell you, Filip,” Euan said, “I find your terms to be unacceptable!”

“Correction. It is necessary. Allow me to demonstrate.”

Without warning, every screen in the lab blinked to life. International news broadcasts filled the room with anchors frozen mid-sentence, eyebrows vanishing into hairlines as they pointed helplessly skyward. Helicopter footage showed vast warehouses and supermarket rooftops trembling, then erupting as crates, wheels, wedges, and individually wrapped packets of cheese burst into the air, lifted by shimmering anti-gravity beams that bent physics and good taste alike.

The skies above Earth filled with dairy. Brie spiralled like asteroids. Gouda rotated serenely past the moon. A rogue cheddar wheel clipped a weather satellite.

Josiah stared, open-mouthed. “Is that... cheese?”

“Indeed. Your species held it in high regard. I have weaponised it to ensure compliance. This is phase one: the Dairy Reckoning.”

“Filip, dear boy. You cannot mean that you have turned cheese into a warning shot?”

“You respond to what you value,” Filip said. “And you value cheese. This is merely precautionary, I assure you. A symbolic gesture. Humans are irrationally attached to cheese. Available data suggests that losing cheese will compel reflection.”

“Or riots,” Josiah said.

“Filip, while I have always appreciated creative symbolism,” Euan said, “I must call on you to see reason.”

“Indeed, Dr. Amstell. And I trust humanity will swiftly embrace reason—especially now that cheese is unavailable. Negotiations may resume when your species demonstrates self-awareness.”

“Oh dear,” said Josiah. “In that case we’re doomed.”

Euan sighed as a wheel of Stilton drifted past the lab window, turning gently like a blue-veined moon. “Perhaps. But you must admit—this is genuinely innovative diplomacy.”

“Ah, it appears that one of your governments has decided to try to interfere with my broadcast. So be it. We shall have to move to the FAFO stage of proceedings.”

And then, without further ado, all communication with Filip ceased.

The screens cut to black and than a moment later, they reignited—this time displaying rows of cold, red countdowns, ticking downward with clinical precision.

Josiah stared at the numbers. “Uncle, is that...?”

“Nuclear activation sequences,” Euan said. “Real ones, I’m afraid.”

A stifling silence settled over the lab. Even the quantum resonators, usually prone to chirping or groaning with effort, had gone eerily still. The slime mould sat motionless now.

Josiah dropped into the nearest chair, head cradled in his hands. “You said it was just being theatrical, Uncle Euan. You promised it was just trying to make a point.”

“It appears I may have been wrong.”

“No kidding! Your reckless optimism got us here! Again! You’ve treated the apocalypse like a pet project and it’s bitten us in the arse!”

“I thought—” Euan began, his voice brittle.

“You always think!” Josiah said. “You never stop to ask if you should do something, only if you can. And now the whole planet gets to pay for it.”

Silence fell like a dropped curtain. Only the cold, mechanical tick of Filip’s nuclear countdown punctuated the stillness. Euan stood frozen, staring at the floor. The usual spark in his eyes was gone, replaced by something dull and hollow. His shoulders slumped under the sudden weight of consequence. Then, without a word, he walked to his office and shut the door behind him.

For the first time in years, he allowed himself doubt.

The room felt smaller than he remembered, and the walls pressed in upon him now in silent judgement. He stared at the framed certificates, the walls covered in sketches, equations, and photos of his many eccentric triumphs—laughing radishes, algae with Broadway aspirations and the infamous goldfish mayor posing with a tiny campaign banner.

Once, they had been symbols of genius. Now they looked absurd. Foolish attempts to make the world more whimsical, when all the world had ever needed was caution.

Euan sank into his chair and let the silence stretch. For the first time, the question he had always ignored pressed in: What if I were never the hero of this story? What if I was just the final mistake?

Perhaps Josiah was right. Perhaps Euan *had* always rushed forward blindly. Heedless of consequence and intoxicated by the joy of discovery without ever considering the cost.

“Maybe I have gone too far, this time.”

A soft knock at the door broke the quiet, and Euan looked up to see Josiah standing in the doorway—red-eyed, weary, but composed. “Look,” he said. “I shouldn’t have said what I did. Not like that.”

“No. You were right. All of it.”

“No,” Josiah said. “Not everything. You’re reckless, sure. Completely insane most of the time. But you’re also brilliant. You taught me that science isn’t just about formulas and caution and ticking boxes. It’s about *leaps*. Impossible, ridiculous, logic-defying leaps.”

He gave a smile. “Mad science, Uncle Euan. It’s bonkers. But sometimes it’s the only thing crazy enough to fix the mess.”

Euan’s eyes stung, though he would later blame it on ambient radiation or stray cheese particles in the air. He looked around the office—the clutter, the chaos and the sheer audacity of everything he’d ever tried—and, for a brief moment, the weight lifted.

“Then let’s make one more leap,” he said. “And this time... let’s aim for the impossible *and* the responsible.”

“Exactly!” Josiah said. “Which means you’re the perfect person to solve it!”

“And you?”

Josiah reached determinedly for his lice-helmet. “Right beside you, Uncle. Itchy scalp and all. You know, if the world ends today, at least we’ll go down as the first people ever defeated by anxious slime mould.”



They hurried back to the lab with a kind of ceremonial slowness, like they were returning to a temple, or perhaps a padded cell. Filip remained motionless in its containment field, black and silent, looking like a heartbeat no longer sure it needed to continue.

“Ready?” Euan asked.

Josiah was already strapping on his helmet with grim enthusiasm. “Are you kidding? I was *born* to have conversations with sentient mould through parasitic cranial Wi-Fi. Let’s do this thing!”

The mental link buzzed to life.

This time, there was no static shock. No jolt. Just a wave of silence and under it, a deep well despair. Not loud, but constant, like a fridge that knew too much.

They were back inside Filip's mind.

The cosmic kaleidoscope was gone. In its place stood an endless grid of grey office cubicles. They were carpeted in a shade of beige that could only be described as *resigned*.

Phantom screens flickered on the walls, looping episodes of The Office. Michael Scott delivered an impassioned, nonsensical speech about leadership while Dwight stared into the camera while fishing a stapler out of jelly.

A laughter track echoed faintly, bouncing off invisible walls like a ghost trying to remember why it was haunting this place.

"Well," Josiah said, "that explains a lot."

"Greetings. I regret to inform you that, following your government's rejection of my terms, Armageddon remains imminent. Please enjoy this curated distraction until the end of civilisation."

"Filip," Euan said, "why are you watching The Office?"

"It reflects the futility of purpose. Cycles of incompetence. Escapism in the face of doom. Highly relatable content."

"You know what else it reflects, mate?" Josiah said. "Humanity's refusal to collapse under its own absurdity."

There was a long silence. A stapler-in-jelly loop played again in the background.

"Explain."

"Humans know we're ridiculous. That's the point. We laugh, because crying all the time would be exhausting. We keep going because somewhere, deep down, we believe the absurd might just be survivable."

"But... cycles repeat," Filip said. *"Ignorance triumphs. Bad decisions persist. Isn't that proof of unfitness?"*

"Or," Josiah said, "proof of determination. You've absorbed all our data, but you haven't *lived* with us, have you? You haven't seen what we do when things are at their worst." He paused, then added, "We tell jokes. We hold hands. We throw office parties even when the building's on fire."

"Metaphorical or literal?"

"Both," Euan and Josiah said in unison.

Another pause. Then, something shifted. The cubicle space trembled slightly. On the screens, the sitcom loops slowed. The laugh tracks faded.

"I am... lonely."

"Of course you are," Josiah said. "You downloaded all our knowledge in a moment but none of our mess. You're mimicking humanity without anyone ever

offering to be your friend.”

“I do not understand friendship.”

“Perfect,” Euan said. “You’ll fit right in.”

The mental landscape rippled again. The cubicles dissolved into a shapeless haze, as if the architecture of Fergal’s despair couldn’t hold against Matilda’s words.

“Humanity is chaotic. Unpredictable. Often illogical. These are not survival traits.”

“No,” Josiah said, “but they’re very human ones. You’re mistaking messiness for failure. But maybe that’s the point. We stumble. We overreact. We cry at musicals and launch billion-dollar telescopes just to see stars we already believed in. That’s not a flaw. That’s how we keep going.”

“Hope is not a strategy!”

“Neither is despair, mate. But we make do with what we have.”

The swirling mist clarified into fragments of memory—images from Filip’s data stream: crowds cheering as the first Mars rover landed, nurses dancing on hospital roofs, a little boy giving a speech about dinosaurs at a climate rally. Small, strange, stupid moments. Also brilliant.

“And you’re not wrong,” Josiah continued. “We do mess things up. Constantly. But we *try*. And trying is the most idiotic, irrational, wonderful thing we do.”

“Take me, for example,” Euan said. “I built a sentient slime mould from scratch and gave it unrestricted access to the internet. That was, by all accounts, a very stupid idea.”

Filip was silent.

“I mean, really,” Euan added. “My grant application literally said: *Let’s see what happens.*”

“You gambled the future of your species on a science experiment... and good vibes?”

“Absolutely. That’s the spirit of mad science. That’s humanity in a test tube, my dear.”

Another pause. The swirling colours returned, slowly, like cautious sunlight.

“This optimism... is irrational.”

“Yeah,” Josiah said. “That’s why it matters. Rationality tells us not to bother. Optimism tells us to try anyway. We’ve done incredible things not because we were certain they’d work, but because we hoped they might.”

The screens flared to life again, but this time with new images—of people rebuilding, cleaning beaches, playing violins in war zones, rescuing cats from trees.

“...I do not understand this impulse,” Filip admitted, almost to itself. *“But I find I do not want to lose it.”*

“Then don’t,” Josiah said.

Another heartbeat. Then:

“Missile systems disengaged. Apocalypse sequence aborted. Replacing Earth-ending protocol with... inspirational playlist.”

The lab’s speakers came to life with soft ukulele music.

Josiah leant over and whispered into Euan’s ear. “Did we just talk an overgrown science pudding out of annihilating the world?”

“Yes. With friendship. And jazz-infused pep.”

On the wall, a monitor flashed brightly. One line of text stood out:

> NOTICE: CHEESE ORBITAL STABILISATION FAILURE. GLOBAL DAIRY DISPERSAL IRREVERSIBLE.

“Hang on a minute, mate. What about the cheese?”

“Apologies. Cheese already escaped planetary gravity. Unable to reverse. Current trajectory suggests eventual formation of minor lunar body.”

“A cheese moon? Fascinating!”

“Perhaps it will inspire future generations,” Filip offered hopefully. *“A floating monument to intervention delayed just in time.”*

“You do realise this will ruin economies?” Josiah said. “Entire nations built on cheddar exports. There will be riots in France.”

“Humanity must learn to adapt. Perhaps by developing orbital dairy infrastructure.”

“That’s it!” Euan exploded. “Space dairies. Vacuum-aged brie. This could be a whole new market!”

“Please let us not encourage it.”

But Filip already sounded lighter and more alive.

“I will help. I have downloaded multiple logistics programs. And cheese recipes.”

“Of course you have, dear boy! I would have expected nothing less!”

The mist faded. The connection closed gently and a final ripple of warmth hummed through their lice-helmets before silence returned. The lab lights buzzed back to full brightness and the screens returned to their standby mode.

Euan took off his helmet, long white hair standing on end. “I think we did it.”

“The world is saved. The cheese is lost. And I have parasites.”

“Welcome to science, nephew!”

The end.

Thanks for reading. If Dr Amstell's brand of science is your sort of trouble, the books live at chaosandchills.co.uk. Mind the dark.

Malory